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Democracy Dies in Darkness

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At Brown, shots, then screams in lecture hall

Teaching assistant held wounded student's hand: 'Put all the pain on me'

BY GAYA GUPTA, TODD WALLACK AND JOANNA SLATER

PROVIDENCE, R.I. — Inside a lecture hall on a darkening winter afternoon, dozens of Brown University students gathered Saturday for a two-hour economics study session, full of urgent questions and pre-exam stress.

Around 4 p.m., the teaching assistant wrapped up with some reassurance: Just try your best on the final, he told the students, many of them in their first semester of college. And even if you fall short, he joked, the consequences won't be life-altering.

Moments later, there was screaming outside the room and several loud bangs. A door opened at the top of the auditorium-style classroom in the Barus and Holley engineering and physics building.

A man dressed all in black, his face covered, burst in. He yelled something unintelligible. He was carrying "the longest gun I've ever seen in my life," said Joseph Oduro, the teaching assistant.

Oduro, 21, locked eyes with the shooter. A single thought went through his mind: Get down.

The assailant opened fire, turning a place of learning into a scene of bloodshed. The attack left two students at the Ivy League school dead and nine others wounded, officials said, spreading terror across campus and around Providence, Rhode Island.

Students spent all night locked down in dorms and university buildings, barricading

SEE **BROWN** ON **A5**

Gun violence: Brown student shot at 15 faced another close call. **A5**

House probe: Smith sought to soften D.C. crime stats

BY OLIVIA GEORGE AND JENNY GATHRIGHT

A months-long congressional investigation accuses the chief of the D.C. police department of incentivizing her subordinates to downplay crimes to maintain an illusion of a safer city, according to a report summarizing the findings obtained by The Washington Post.

Based on interviews with all seven current D.C. police district commanders plus one who is on leave, the Republican-led House Oversight Committee said Pamela A. Smith "propagated an ecosystem of fear, retaliation, and toxicity" — another salvo in the power struggle between federal and local authorities over public safety in the nation's capital.

The report arrives days after a leaked draft from a Justice Department investigation into the police department found Smith created a "coercive culture of fear" that may have encouraged the manipulation of crime statistics. It book-

SEE **POLICE** ON **A2**



SALWAN GEORGES/THE WASHINGTON POST

Floods threaten one of the driest places on Earth

In Oman, extreme rainfall has become frequent and deadly

BY JOSHUA PARTLOW, SALWAN GEORGES AND BEN NOLL IN SAMAD AL-SHAN, OMAN

On their final morning together in April of last year, two elderly sheikhs in a white Mercedes drove through a palm-tree-lined ravine to pay their respects at a funeral.

The two local leaders were cousins and best friends, traveled the world together and prayed at the same mosque. They lived on the same block in Samad al-Shan, a village amid the rocky hills south of Muscat that was built along one of hundreds of wadis — normally dry riverbeds — in one of the most water-scarce countries in the world.

Floods in this part of Oman, while rare, are not unheard of. Elders remembered that villagers used to fire guns to alert those

downstream that water was coming. But as sheikhs Saif and Naser al-Mawaly drove through the date palm groves that morning, they had little warning beyond the steadily darkening sky that more than a year's worth of rain would soon fall on their village.

"No one expected this," said Saif's son Yahya, an engineer. "It was the strongest storm of their entire lives."

The storm system first dropped the most rain the United Arab Emirates had seen since records began 75 years earlier. It swamped Dubai's subway, flooded its airport (the second-busiest in the world) and led to a

SEE **OMAN** ON **A12**

Yousuf Mawaly, right, with his nephew Yahya al-Mawaly and his son Saif al-Mawaly, 9, visits the graves of two family members who lost their lives during a 2024 flood in Samad al-Shan.

Europe tries to reverse shrinking population

BY CHICO HARLAN

BUDAPEST — After years of people having fewer children, Europe is on the brink of a great contraction. Next year, the European Union expects its population to hit a peak before sliding into the first sustained decline on the continent since the 14th-century Black Death.

That trajectory has raised

alarms about shrinking workforces and the possibility of economic insolvency. So governments of every political stripe are scrambling to test whether some mix of perks, incentives and ideology might spark a baby boom.

Countries across Scandinavia have launched commissions to recommend new strategies, while soul-searching over why

their famously strong welfare programs couldn't prevent a fertility rate nosedive. In France, President Emmanuel Macron has talked of the need to "demographically rearm" the nation after fertility rates fell 18 percent over a decade. And in a handful of countries with nationalist leaders, governments are rolling out generous financial incentives

SEE **POPULATION** ON **A10**

Gunmen kill 15 at Hanukkah event in Australia

FATHER, SON ACTED TOGETHER, POLICE SAY

Jewish leaders say they warned of rising antisemitism

BY MICHAEL E. MILLER, MEG KELLY, SAMMY WESTFALL AND SUSANNAH GEORGE

SYDNEY — Two gunmen opened fire on a Hanukkah celebration Sunday at Bondi Beach, killing 15 people and wounding at least 40 others in what Australian officials said was an act of terrorism targeting the city's Jewish community.

Jewish leaders in Sydney reacted with grief and rage, after what they said were months of unheeded warnings about the dangers of rising antisemitism. In the wake of the attack, police in Australia stepped up security at synagogues, as did authorities in New York, London and elsewhere.

Australian Prime Minister Anthony Albanese called the shooting — the deadliest in this country in almost three decades — "an act of evil antisemitism, terrorism, that has struck the heart of our nation."

Rabbi Moshe Gutnick of Syd-

ney was at the event with his son-in-law and grandchildren. He said his family hid under a picnic table as people were gunned down around them. Among the dead were two of his best friends and a colleague.

"It's unfathomable," he said.

The attack

The annual celebration to mark the first night of Hanukkah, sponsored by the Chabad of Bondi, was scheduled for 5 p.m. near the playground at a Bondi Beach park, according to an online flier. About 1,000 people had gathered to mark the occasion.

A 10-minute video by an unknown witness, as well as more than half a dozen other videos and photos verified and analyzed by The Washington Post, show how the violence unfolded.

Late in the 6 p.m. hour, almost two hours after the celebration began, the extended video shows a gunman in khaki pants and a black, short-sleeved shirt fire at

SEE **BONDI** ON **A11**



RONEN ZVULUN/REUTERS

A vigil in Tel Aviv takes place near the beach Sunday night after the shooting at Sydney's Bondi Beach during Hanukkah celebrations.

Trump eyes 'unique' building for presidential library in Fla.

But the plan raises concerns about secrecy, bias, funding sources

BY MICHAEL KRANISH AND LORI ROZSA

Eric Trump sounded triumphant after Florida officials recently approved giving away a prized piece of Miami real estate for his father's presidential library. "I got the library approved yesterday," Trump said on a podcast, adding that "we just got the greatest site in Florida, and I'm going to be building that."

Then, speaking on another program, Trump said he would take the host's suggestion to create a "fake news wing" — paid for with money from lawsuit settlements with ABC, CBS and other sources. It would run clips from "60 Minutes" and other programs that he said were evidence of the media organizations' animus against his father.

These little-noticed statements by the president's son provide a

revealing look into the zeal of President Donald Trump and his family to build a likely high-rise with a museum that they say will be unlike any other presidential library — and which could tell the story of his presidency only as he wants it to be told.

Much about the process is secretive, with no federal rules requiring disclosure of the donors — some of whom may have interests affected by White House policy — who are expected to provide hundreds of millions of dollars. A recent filing, for example, says the Donald J. Trump Library Foundation raised \$50 million this year but doesn't provide any donor names. It says \$6 million has been spent for "program services" but doesn't provide specifics.

The White House referred questions to the foundation, which did not respond to an emailed list of queries and has not said whether Trump might use some of the site for a hotel or other development.

It is also unclear whether the Trump Library will function as the name implies — providing a center for research of presidential

SEE **LIBRARY** ON **A18**

IN THE NEWS

Leaning into isolation Amid foreign and domestic difficulties, the Trump administration has enacted policies that block foreign influences. **A3**

A cold shoulder Protests and attacks in Ireland mark an unusual backlash against asylum seekers in the country. **A8**

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After a tumultuous first term, there have been few firings in Trump's Cabinet. **A4**
A library board in N.C. was dissolved after deciding to keep a book about a trans boy. **A7**

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The next star of Hallmark's Christmas movie is being chosen through — what else? — a reality show. **B1**

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Patrick Mahomes suffered a torn ACL, and the Kansas City Chiefs' playoff streak came to an end Sunday. **C1**

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